Beyond aid and credit, India is also increasingly willing and able to provide humanitarian assistance and disaster relief (HADR). While the Indian armed services have conducted HADR operations farther afield—from Libya to Fiji—the majority of its recent overseas experience has been in the immediate neighbourhood, setting a strong precedent for India as a first responder in its region. For example, after Cyclone Sidr hit Bangladesh in November 2007, the Indian Navy used amphibious ships to deliver emergency food aid to Chittagong. In 2014, when an accident crippled the Maldives water supply, the Indian Air Force and Navy delivered fresh water. Following the devastating earthquake in Nepal in April 2015, India began to airlift relief materials within hours, and worked to evacuate Indian citizens and other foreign nationals. And in May 2017, when Sri Lanka experienced heavy flooding and deadly mudslides that left hundreds homeless, India diverted navy ships with relief assistance and provided divers and medical personnel. [14]

Many of India's efforts at increasing assistance—particularly long-term project financing—are intended to improve connectivity between India and its neighbours. This includes efforts to improve or facilitate the regulated flow of goods, capital, people, energy, and data across borders. It is often said that South Asia is the least connected region in the world. This is not entirely accurate. Although India is poorly integrated with Pakistan, its other relationships enjoy considerable and growing interconnectivity and interdependence. For example, Nepal and India enable visa-free travel and employment across their border. Bangladesh and India have seen increased cross-border road, rail, and electric grid connectivity. Direct flights between India and Sri Lanka have increased and the Maldives works closely with India on such matters as healthcare and emergency services. But further improving integration will require India to develop both the 'hardware' (roads, railways, ports, pipelines, electrical grids, satellites, inland waterways, and broadband cables) as well as the 'software' (customs facilities, consular arrangements, motor vehicle agreements, and common standards) of connectivity. [15]